Psychological and Sociocultural Adaptation of Asylum-Seekers and Refugees

A Thematic-Analysis in Germany, Malaysia, and Portugal

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This work is supported by FCT - Fundação para a Ciência e Tecnologia, I.P. by project reference and DOI identifier, https://doi.org/10.54499/2023.02579.BDANA


Face death in a war zone?
Escape, but leave loved ones behind?
What would you do?
For many refugees the choice is between the horrific or something worse. No one chooses to become a refugee. UNHCR helps those who are forced to flee to find safety, regain hope and rebuild their lives. 1 family torn apart by war is too many. takeaction.unhcr.org – because you do have a choice.
UNHCR
The UN Refugee Agency



Asylum-Seekers

An asylum-seeker is someone who is seeking international protection. Their request for refugee status, or complementary protection status, has yet to be processed, or they may not yet have requested asylum but they intend to do so.

Refugees

Refugees are people forced to flee their own country and seek safety in another country. They are unable to return to their own country because of feared persecution as a result of who they are, what they believe in or say, or because of armed conflict, violence or serious public disorder.

Psychological ADAPTATION

Psychological adaptation refers to a person's overall emotional or psychological well-being, where people find ways to cope with stress in a new environment.

Sociocultural ADAPTATION

Sociocultural adaptation refers to the success in acquiring the culturally-appropriate skills to effectively navigate and negotiate everyday life in the new culture.

Searle, W., & Ward, C. (1990). The prediction of psychological and sociocultural adjustment during cross-cultural transitions. International Journal of Intercultural Relations, 14(4), 449–464. https://doi.org/10.1016/0147-1767(90)90030-Z





Research QUESTIONS

- How do asylum-seekers and refugees adapt to post-arrival conditions?
- What does psychological and sociocultural adaptation mean to asylum-seekers and refugees?
- What are the similarities across different country contexts?
- What are the contextual differences?

Methods

- Qualitative Analysis - Reflexive Thematic Analysis (Braun & Clarke, 2022)
- Hybrid using both emic and etic approach

STUDY DESIGN

- Focus group discussions (4 Germany, 4 Portugal, 6 Malaysia) in 2025
- Semi-structured interview
  - What were some of the challenges that you faced in the first few months of arrival?
  - How have you changed when you first arrived till today?

Participants

- Participants - 74
- Country of Origin - 9
- Average Age - 38.33 years (18 - 61 years)
- Average Stay - 3.37 years (2 weeks - 17 years)
- Gender - 40.54% male





Survival

In their home countries, **survival** meant escaping violence and staying alive.

In the receiving country, **survival** means avoiding unwanted attention and earning a living.



Sociocultural Adaptation

Pragmatic Communication - the acquisition of functional linguistic and non-verbal skills necessary to navigate essential daily transactions.

- “when we go market even they know the English, they never say and they use only Malaysian language. So are some people they understand what they say they don't know and they just show them and hand hand language and finger. Yeah, 'how much?' if she ask. Something like that. They show with hand.”

Technology-Assisted Learning - skill acquisition with the assistance of mobile applications and online resources during post-arrival adjustment.

- “Thanks God for ChatGPT, seriously, because no one is able to explain the local laws, the requirements, the documents that are needed, who depends on whom, how the structure, the school system, the clinics, like medical system works.”

Strategic Cultural Blending - the ability to employ strategies minimizing stigmatized cultural markers in the receiving society.

- “I already felt like too tall, too white, too something else, too skinny, to everything in a bad way. So I was just like, ‘okay, I want to blend in. At least I will learn the language, I will blend in.’“

Negative Psychological Adaptation

Irregular Sleep Patterns - abnormal sleeping behaviour post-arrival.

- “You know, they stay here. Its just, then sleeping becomes our coping mechanism. You know when we are doing nothing, our body shuts down, yeah. That's how it is.“

Longing for Home - persistent nostalgia and emotional attachment to homeland, relationships, and life circumstances.

- “And a lot of time I cried and I had a lot of fight with (husband). 'Do why we are here? Why have we changed this?' It was really not easy.”

Hopeless Stagnation - the feeling of being stuck between the impossibility of return and the inability to progress in the receiving country.

- “I'm coming for here for. My life is better in this time, but I am sleep. I am living in the five month here, but for me I need, for me, everything is my time. Why I’m five months is here living? Why I'm not go to working?”





Positive Psychological Adaptation

Sense of Safety - A subjective feeling of being protected from harm.

- “The Portugal name comes at the range of four, four best secure country in the world. And for that, for this moment, I'm so happy. I'm very happy because whenever the life will be secure, we can do everything.”

Restored Agency - the reclamation of personal control, self-reliance, and proactive decision-making.

- “I have learned how to survive alone and how to, you know, communicate with different kinds of people, how to live together with different kind of people. I can say now that I am perfectly ready to work, you know, and to handle the situations. Because living in this camp has taught me a lot, especially patience, how to live with six roommates”

Thankfulness - felt appreciation after achieving stability and retrospectively recognise assistance from individuals, communities, governments, or divine forces.

- “in here a lot of Myanmar people is here and they, she want to say, everything we can stay here. We can work, we can support our family with the salary. So the thing is I want to say, thank you for this Malaysian.“



Germany
Bed Swaps

Asylum-seekers subject to Dublin Regulation deploy temporary "bed circulation" as a protective strategy to evade arrest and forced return.

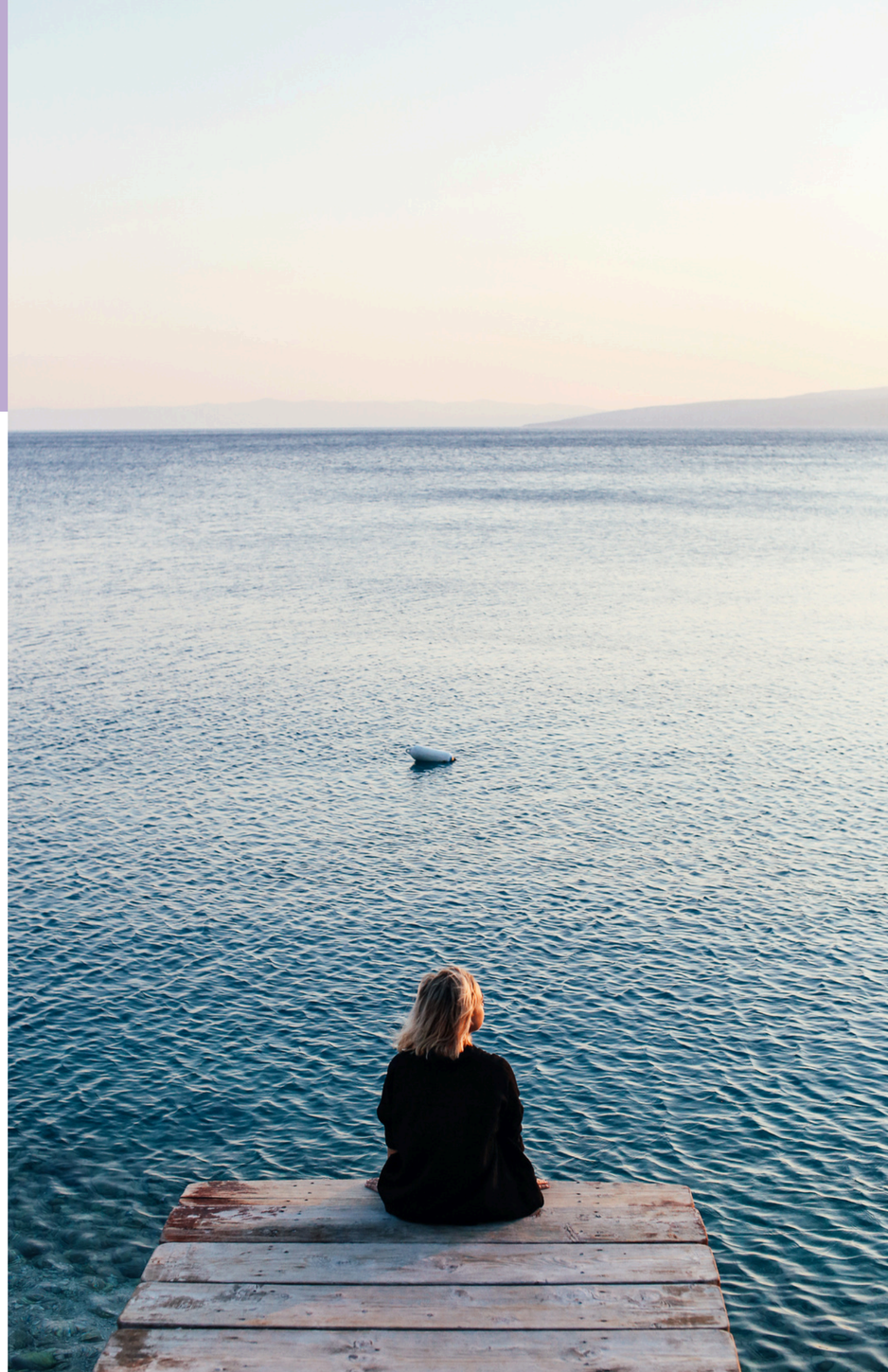
“Sometimes we sleep, we change the rooms. Like my name is in one room and I sleep another room. When police come into my room and my friends call me then. 'The police coming, leave the other rooms too', and then I leave and go outside.”

Portugal

NEGOTIATED CALM

Calma, or ‘be calm’, is a cultural script encountered in Portugal that functions both as a supportive psychological resource and as a mechanism that normalises administrative delays, requiring individuals to adapt their expectations rather than challenging institutional inefficiency.

“OK, you don't have these documents for two months. OK, nothing happened. ‘Calma’ like, OK. And then I started to like, feel the same. OK, I don't have these documents, but I will have this time, it's ‘don't worry now about bureaucracy.’”





Malaysia

STAY INDOORS

Daily life is structured around avoiding the predatory police, where refugees meticulously plan their movements around police routines, restricted to specific 'safe' zones and times

“She said that when she arrive, she is afraid to go out. She was afraid to go out. She was afraid to go to even even go to church. But now, she said that she can go out by herself. And even when she met with police, she have confidence to go.“



Discussion

- Context: Adaptation is fundamentally shaped by legal status and systemic constraints.
- Psychological: Centers on survival, safety, and the reclamation of agency.
- Sociocultural: Driven by strategic, pragmatic, and functional skill acquisition.

Limitations

- Local-community as interpreters
- Non-native English participants
- Preliminary analysis

FUTURE

- Examine adaptation logitudinally
- Explore adaptation with children
- Part of the PhD Scale Development Project



Thanks
SO MUCH!

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